

true, check it out with the FTC or one of the consumer groups online that monitor fraud.

In the category of dishonest and illegal, consider advance-fee loan scams. You see an ad from a company that guarantees approval for a loan or other type of credit but requires you to pay a fee before you apply. Most legitimate lenders won't guarantee that you'll get a loan until after they've thoroughly reviewed your application and checked out your credit history. Advance-fee loans are illegal. You'll never see the loan. Similar scams exist for credit cards. You're promised a credit card, guaranteed, even though your credit history is so bad that no lender dares extend you credit. All you have to do is pay a fee up front. Once again, you'll never see the credit card.

Don't Be a Victim

Some scams have been around for years, yet there are new victims every day. "Make money from home" scams, nonexistent charities, investment "opportunities" that promise you a high rate of return or a chance to buy in at a discount—any of these should make you very skeptical.

In addition, no reputable company will require your social security number in order for you to claim a prize you won, and nobody needs your bank account number for any legitimate purpose.